



ALL TIME MUSIC: An episode from the Zee TV talent hunt show *SaReGaMaPa*

transformed Indian television, promising fame and fortune to the couch potatoes. Star Plus, the channel that aired KBC, morphed into channel number one, with its audience of 22 million people, when the show was first aired in 2001, surging to over 61 million viewers in the year 2005 when the second season was launched. The traffic was such that servers were streamlined to conform to a peak load requirement in excess of 4,000 SMSes per second.

It was the start of a reality television boom which has put the mass into mass media, making heroes out of nobodies. As India's appetite for vicarious living grows, so does the viewership, from 2,98,369 minutes across all channels in 2005 to 3,93,702 minutes in 2006. It's also a genre that is standing at the cusp of a technological revolution, allowing Indians to access their growing mobile subscriber base to get their opinions across. So from 5 crore votes in the first *Indian Idol* finale, the response grew to 7 crore in the

third. It's a decisive viewership.

It wasn't easy. Nikhil Alva of Miditech, which produced the first reality soap (*Hospital* on BBC), recalls the early days: "Programming heads would say 'Indians have too much reality in their lives' and are only interested in fictional worlds when they get home as an escape." Everything changed after Sony broadcast *Indian Idol*, a mix of two great Indian pastimes: having their say and singing Hindi film songs.

Now, there is a reality TV show in every genre. There are singing shows (like *SaReGaMaPa*), dance shows (like *Jhalak DikhlaJaa*), comedy shows (*Great Indian Laughter Challenge*) and even one for weight loss (*Biggest Loser Jeetega*). Every new entertainment channel also has its own driver shows, like *Say Shaava Shaava* for NDTV Imagine.

The shows on air are a mix of made-in-India formats and those licensed from abroad. Of late, broadcasters have become wary of

international formats as they are expensive and limit the ability to make changes depending on the competition. Formats usually cost 5 to 7 per cent of the overall production budget (for a show like *Indian Idol*, it is Rs 25 crore) and typically 50 per cent of telephony revenues go to the format holders as well. Format holders also charge a consultancy fee (between \$50,000 and \$1,00,000 or Rs 20,00,000 and Rs 40,00,000) for experts to ensure the show is produced to exact international specifications.

Even as India awaits a new generation of reality shows, broadcasters scour trade shows for the next big thing. Till then, reality television is acquiring a place in India's social fabric, from giving Nepalis a reason to celebrate by voting for a policeman as the new *Indian Idol 3* to creating a new type of celebrity, who is famous for seeking fame. In the western countries, where there is currently a crisis of drama in the soap, successful shows have picked up reality television traits, such as in *The Office* and *Lost*. In India, where the saas-bahu sagas are clearly at a downswing after seven years, the drama-and-mas-cara-laden reality shows may well be the new addiction. ■

NIKHIL ALVA, CEO, Miditech, 2005

"Viewers have seen what the shows can do. They are a short cut to fame, a bloodless revolution."